

Karnak Temple Complex

A site of immense cultural significance and a principal source of knowledge about ancient Egyptian civilization



The massive temple complex on the east bank of the Nile at Karnak, near Luxor, is Egypt's most visited site after the pyramids at Giza (see pp.208–209). It includes a vast range of structures—from temples, chapels, giant obelisks, and massive gateways (pylons) to sphinxes, sacred lakes, and a hypostyle (columned) hall (see pp.212–213).

Sites of worship

The site has three existing main temple precincts dedicated to gods: those of Mont, the god of war, in the north; Mut, the Earth goddess and wife of Amun, in the south; and between these two, by far the largest and most important, the precinct of Amun, the greatest of all gods. The prominence of Karnak derives from the Temple of Amun, particularly from the New Kingdom (c.1539–1075 BCE), when it assumed preeminent religious significance as the center dedicated to his cult.

One of Karnak's most spectacular features is its enormous hypostyle hall; around 54,000 square ft (5,000 square m) in area, it includes 134 massive columns—the majority 33 ft (10 m) high, with architraves that weigh 154,000 lb (70,000 kg)—notable for their deeply incised hieroglyphs, designed to prevent erasure by subsequent rulers.

Karnak is unique among Egypt's sites for the length of time it took to build—the complex was under continual construction for some 2,000 years, beginning during the Middle Kingdom (c.1980–1630 BCE) and ending in Ptolemaic times (305–30 BCE). It was designated a World Heritage Site in 1979.

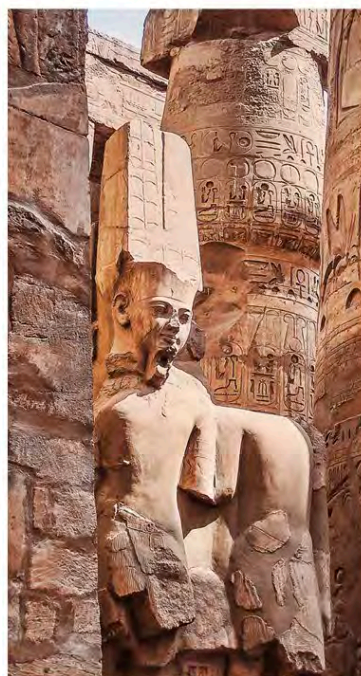
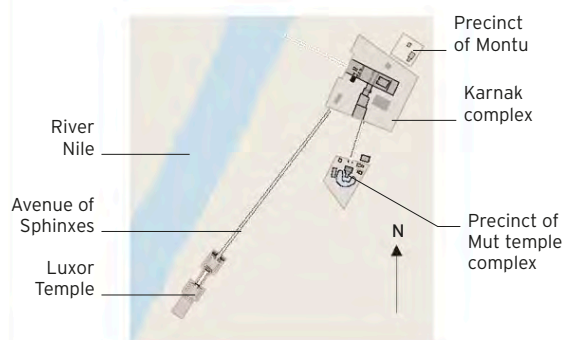
▷ ANCIENT COLUMNS

The columns at Karnak were built to massive proportions and deeply inscribed to ensure the pharaohs' place in history. Originally, they would have been vibrantly painted.

Some **30 pharaohs** were involved in Karnak's **construction**

KARNAK TO LUXOR: THE SACRED ROAD

The temples of Karnak and the nearby Luxor are linked by an avenue of human-headed sphinxes, almost 2 miles (3 km) long. The avenue originally served as the outbound processional route of the annual Opet festival, which reenacted the marriage of the gods Amun and Mut; the spectacular procession then returned on the Nile on barques. A series of magnificent reliefs at Karnak record the movement of the barques.



△ GREAT HYPOSTYLE HALL

The monumental hypostyle hall, one of Karnak's highlights, was used for religious ceremonies and would only have been accessed by priests and rulers.

◁ STATUE OF AMUN

The god Amun, depicted here in human form, would have been honored daily by priests at his spectacular temple at Karnak.